



TOM FRANKLIN/Staff

Getting closer: Work is under way at the new site of the Carolina Raptor Center. Herman Caudle of Neill Grading Co. (from left) and volunteers Jim Arthur and Jim Fella put down fabric where gravel will cover the driveway.

New Raptor Center facility taking wing

Construction beginning on education building

By GAIL SMITH
Staff Writer

For six or seven years, a sign beside Sample Road said, "The Future Home of the Carolina Raptor Center."

The future is now: Center staffers have tacked a wooden board over part of the sign so it now reads, "Soon to be the Carolina Raptor Center."

That's because work is under way at the site of the Edna Moretti Environmental Education Center. Last week, workers were grading the parking lot site, and later this month construction should start on the foundation.

The 4,000-square-foot center — scheduled to be completed by late this year — will hold offices, an exhibit hall, a large meeting room, a gift shop and an aviary for screech owls.

The screech owls won't be the only striking feature of the new building.

Dick Gibson of Lake Wylie is creating two works out of stained glass — two 3½-foot-diameter circular windows. One will depict a bald eagle flying through the clouds, and another will

reveal a barred owl peering through tree branches.

Gibson is donating both windows to the nonprofit center.

"I think once the word gets out about these windows, people will come just to see them. From what I've seen, they're beautiful," said center Director Pat Marcum.

She said Gibson is a friend of a center board member.

The windows will be framed and hung so the light shines through them in the exhibit hall. Eventually, they may be framed into the walls when the center expands.

After the present construction is completed, the center will be able to offer programs in the new education room, which will seat 50 to 75 people. The exhibit hall, Marcum said, will have

20-foot ceilings and feature changing exhibits such as wildlife art shows.

The hall "will be almost like a little museum," she said.

The construction program won't end with the completion of the education center.

Marcum has met with an architect who is interested in donating his services to design a hospital for the care of injured birds. She said she'd like to see a hospital operating in the next three years, "although the board has to consider and decide these things."

Now, the center's hospital operates out of a trailer. In a new building, center staffers might have operating rooms, research and treatment rooms and an isolation area.

The Raptor Center was able to raise \$220,000 needed to build the education center building and may have an easier time getting money for a hospital, Marcum said.

"A lot of people are very interested in taking care of the injured birds. Our

goal is education of the public. Rehabilitation is our secondary goal, although we're one of the biggest rehab centers in the United States," Marcum said.

"As soon as we're into the environmental education center, I hope our board will begin raising money for the hospital."

She said it does take time to raise money, even with significant donations, like the \$100,000 donated for the education center by Fred and Edna Moretti of Moretti Construction Co. of Charlotte.

"It took us 1½ years to raise money for the environmental education center, and that's with a large donation to start out with," Marcum said.

Some of the other large donors to the education center are the Cannon Foundation, Concord, \$10,000; Neill Grading and Construction Co., Hickory, site grading; Superior Paving Co., Statesville, rolling gravel in parking areas; Jack Wooten Trucking Co., Statesville, trucks to haul gravel; and Martin Marietta Co., Charlotte, 50 truckloads of gravel.

In addition, Mecklenburg County had agreed to donate \$40,000 from the county Park and Recreation Department budget, when the center raised \$80,000 (which it has done).



Marcum